

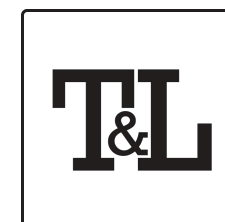
A UDL Approach to Transparent and Inclusive Assessment

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NATIONAL FORUM
FOR THE ENHANCEMENT OF TEACHING
AND LEARNING IN HIGHER EDUCATION



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Acknowledgement:

Developed with support from the IADT Teaching and Learning Office.

Title:

Building Better Briefs: A UDL Approach to Transparent and Inclusive Assessment

**Institute of Art, Design + Technology,
Ireland**

Year Published:

2026

OER description:

An open educational resource for higher education staff who design assessment briefs. It provides a structured approach to writing clear, consistent and accessible briefs, aligning learning outcomes, assessment tasks and assessment criteria. It includes reusable guidance and a brief template that can be adapted across disciplines.

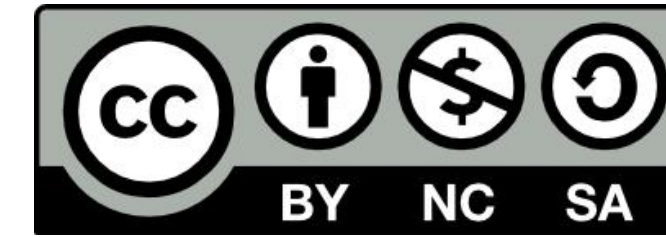
Funding and licence

Funding:

Funded through the Strategic Alignment of Teaching and Learning Enhancement Funding (SATLE), administered by the Higher Education Authority and the National Forum for the Enhancement of Teaching and Learning in Higher Education.

Licence:

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Share and adapt

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Licence scope:

Applies to the presentation, written guidance and reusable brief template. Software source code, IADT branding and third-party material are excluded.

Project overview

A UDL Approach to Transparent and Inclusive Assessment

This SATLE-supported project explores how assessment briefs can become clearer, more accessible and easier to use.

The OER combines research-informed guidance with a downloadable brief builder that runs locally in a web browser.

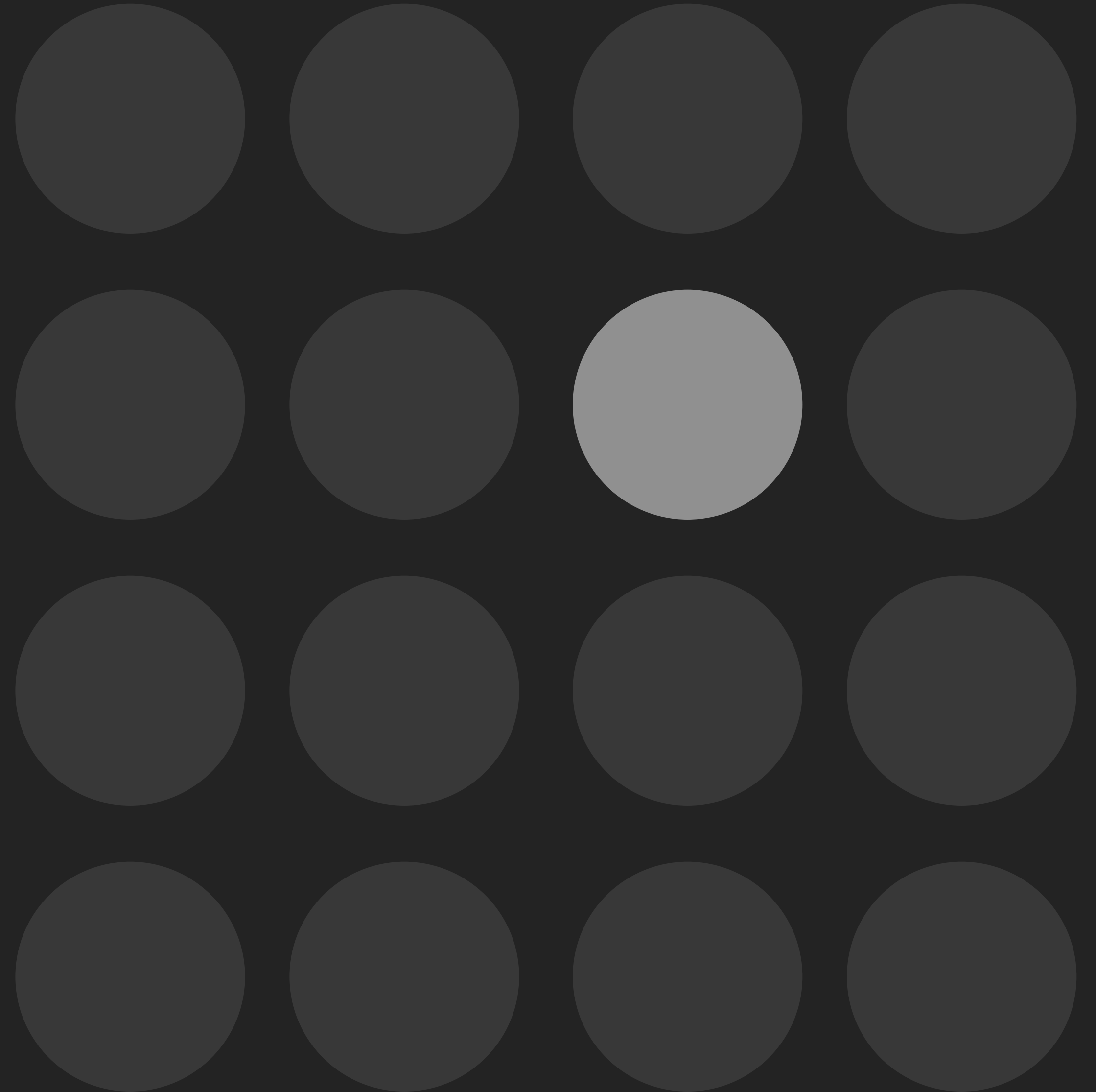
Project Details

Project Overview	Listen to this section 🔊	
	Your task is to design a prototype for a website catering to third-level students in their final year who are seeking information on opportunities for progression into employment or further study.	
Learning Outcomes Assessed	1	Critically evaluate and select appropriate Universal and Inclusive Design principles, methodologies, and standards across a range of design contexts and experiences.
	2	Demonstrate the ability to design accessible and inclusive user experiences that accommodate diverse user needs and contexts.
	3	Analyse and apply legal, ethical, and societal considerations in Universal and Inclusive Design.
	4	Develop practical design solutions that address barriers to access and promote long-term usability, sustainability, and inclusion.
	5	Critically reflect on the ethical, social, and environmental impact of design decisions, demonstrating an ability to evaluate personal and professional practice in Universal and Inclusive Design.
(See Rubric Below) ↓		
Deliverables	Listen to this section 🔊	
	Your task is to design a prototype for a website catering to third-level students in their final year who are seeking information on opportunities for progression into employment or further study.	
Resources	Listen to this section 🔊	
	Academic Sources	+
	Jon Yablonski	+
	Podcast	+
Relevant Books, Journals, Texts, Websites, etc.		

“

**Open approaches support
a more equitable and flexible
learning environment.**

SPARC Europe, Connecting the Opens II:
The Drivers of Openness in Higher Education (2025)



One Simple Question:

How can we make assessment briefs clearer for students?

Many students struggle with ambiguity rather than ability.

Assessment briefs and rubrics are often:

- difficult to interpret
- inconsistent across modules
- written using abstract academic language
- inaccessible in structure and format

Uniformity
Structure

Abstract geometric shapes on a dark background. The shapes include a long, thin rectangle, a smaller rectangle, a triangle, and a circle, all in various shades of gray. They are arranged in a way that suggests a sense of movement or a sequence of elements.

The Hidden Problem

Students interpret rubrics + Briefs differently



Students from different backgrounds, disciplines, and levels of experience often interpret the same assessment criteria in very different ways.

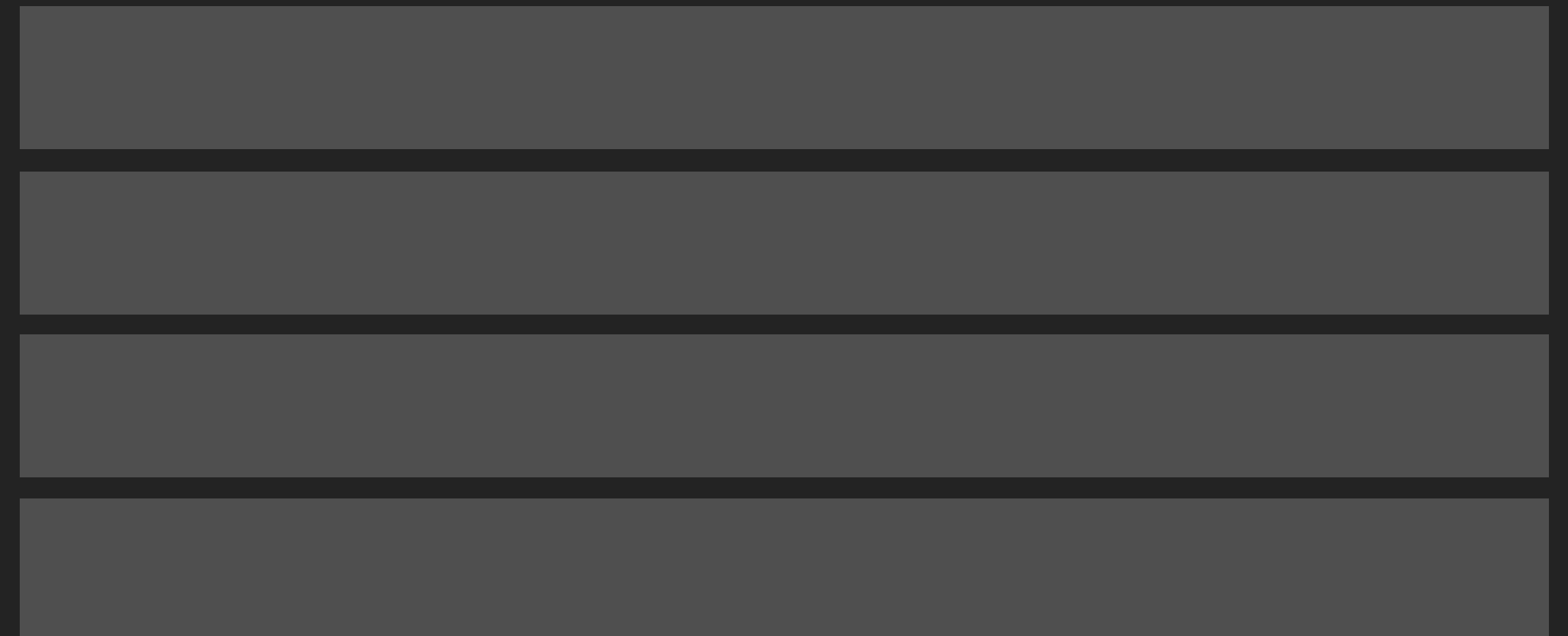
The Disciplinary Lens

Many students struggle with ambiguity rather than ability.

Different disciplines value different forms of knowledge, process, evidence and expression.

A consistent structure should still allow lecturers to adapt the brief to their subject and assessment.

Uniformity
Structure

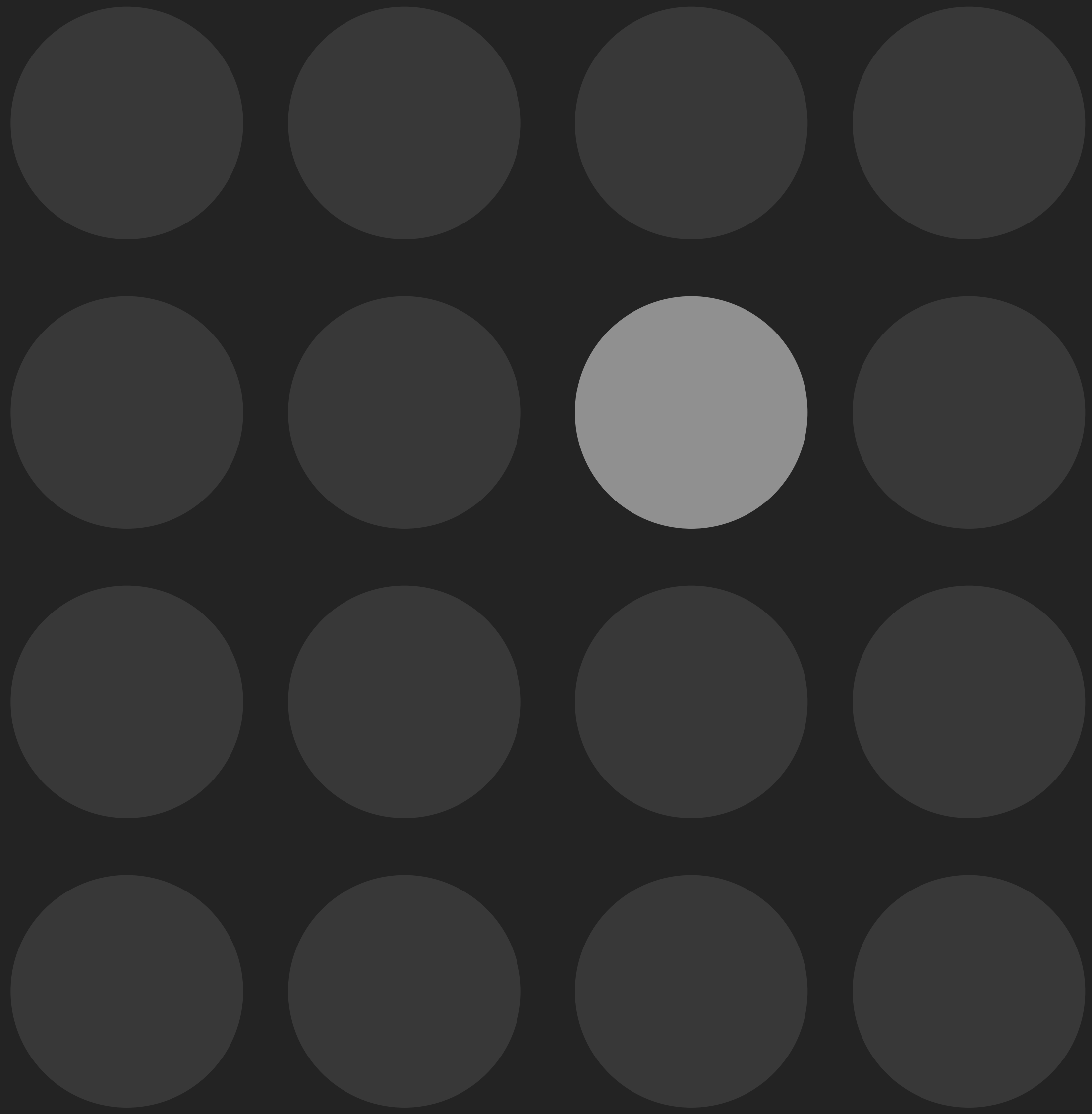


Institutional Challenge

Inconsistency creates 🧠💥

As complexity increases, students may spend more time decoding assessment requirements than engaging with their learning.

Clear and consistent briefs can reduce unnecessary cognitive load.

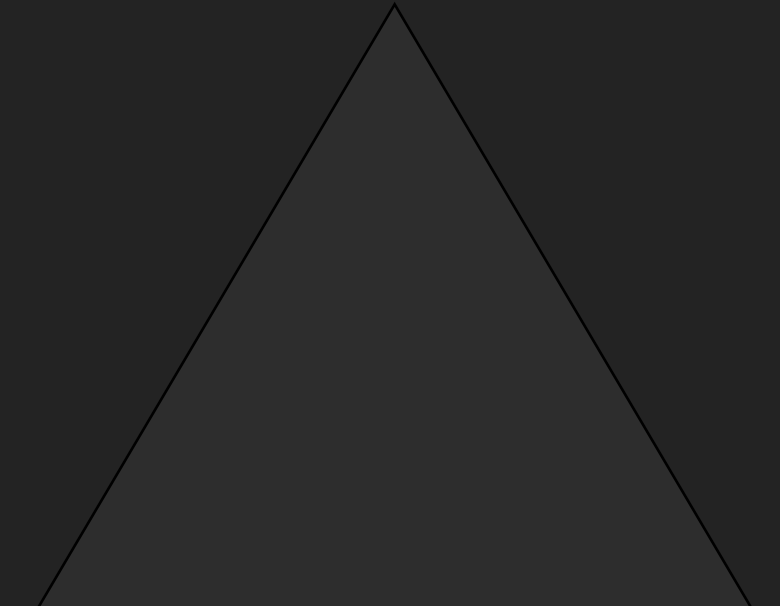
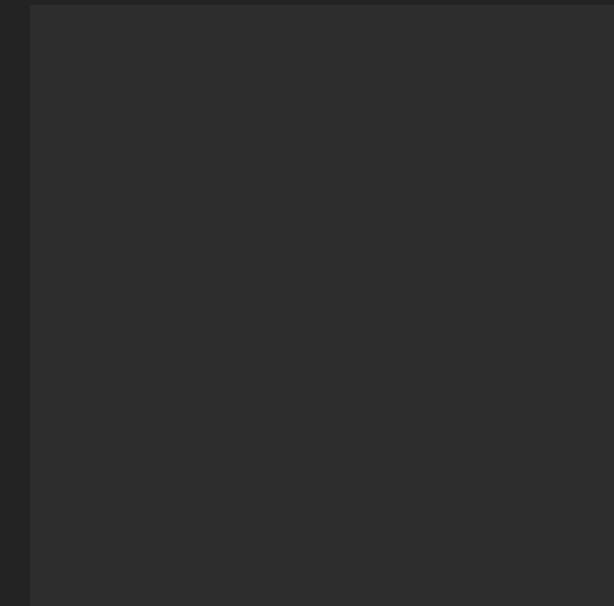
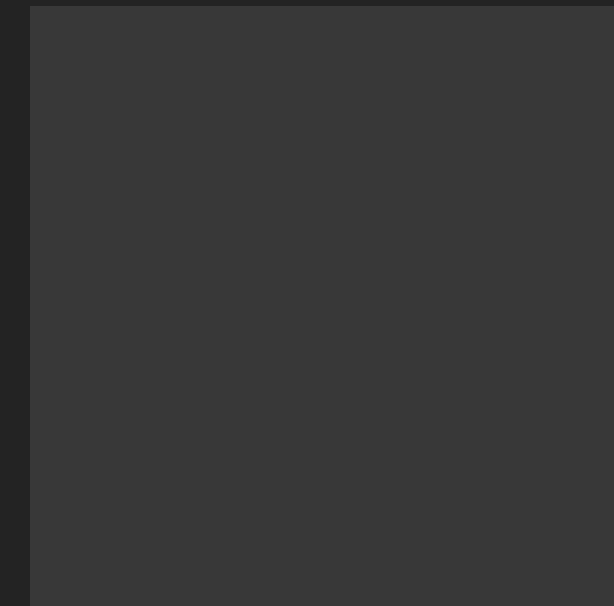
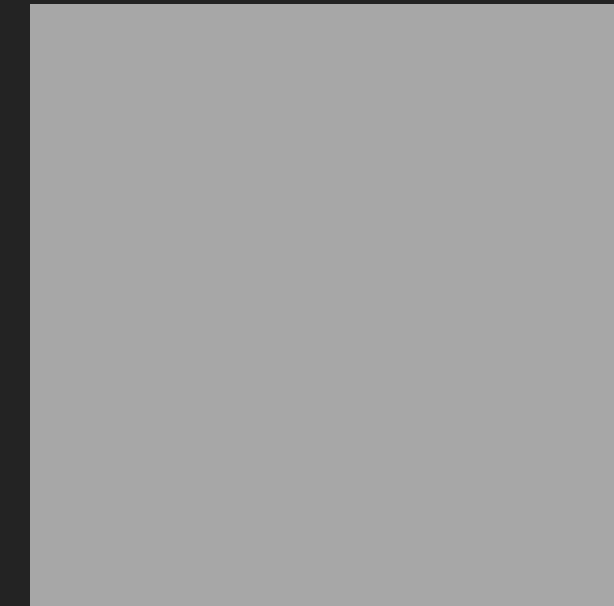
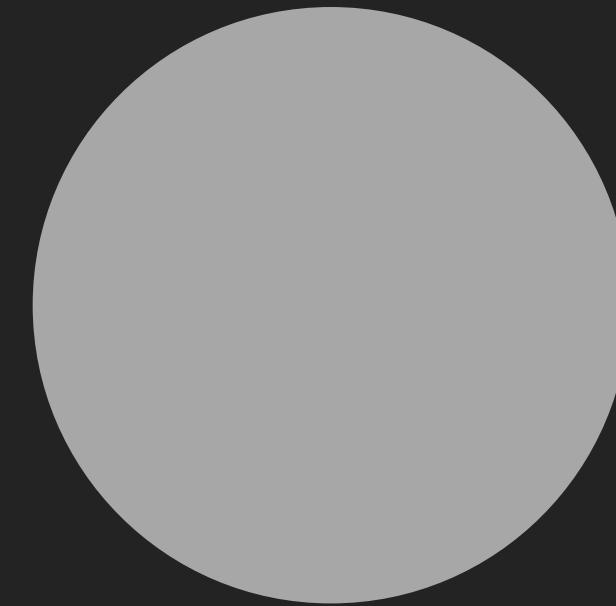
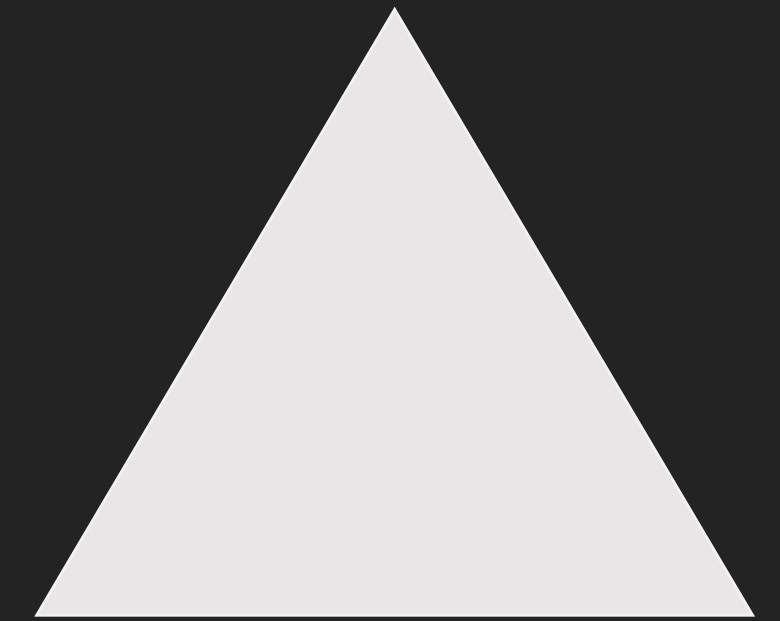
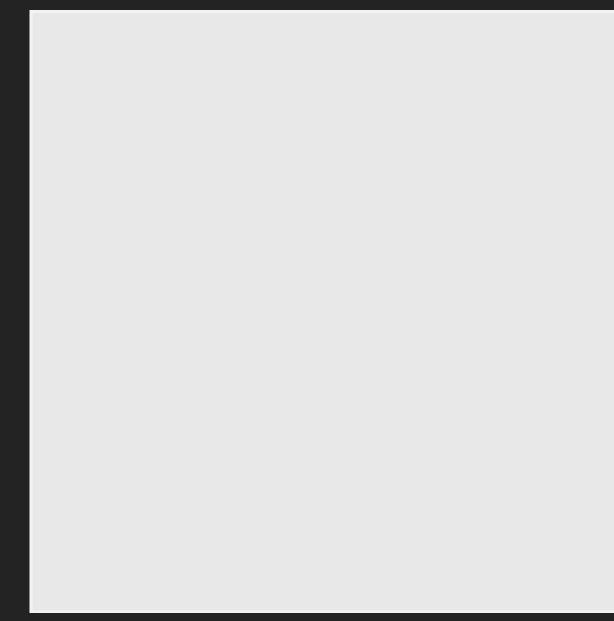
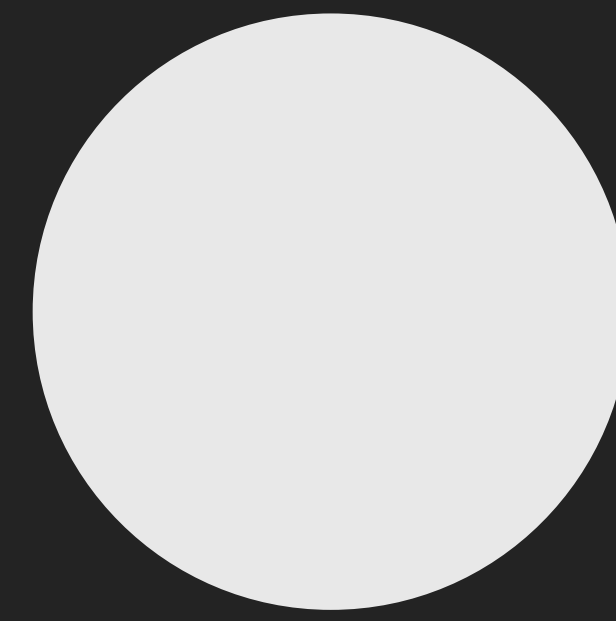


The Opportunity

Assessment briefs can support learning as well as communicate requirements.

A well-designed brief helps students understand:

- What they need to do
- Why they are doing it
- How their work will be assessed



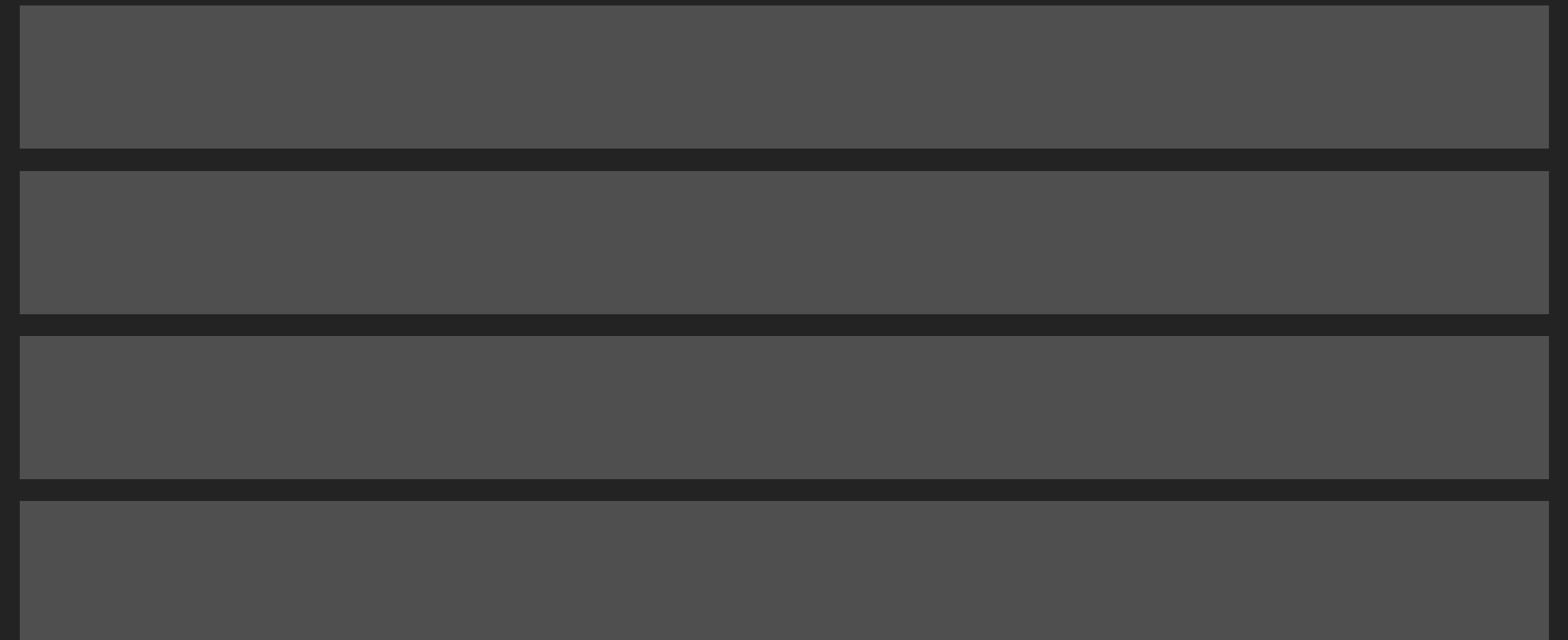
Design Principles

The project was guided by a small set of practical design principles:

The OER follows a small set of practical principles:

- Clear, student-facing language
- Alignment between outcomes, tasks + criteria
- Consistent information structure
- Accessible presentation
- Flexibility across disciplines

ABC



The OER

Clearer and more inclusive assessment design.

The stripped-back OER provides:

- A guided assessment brief builder
- A consistent brief structure
- Clear student-facing content
- Alignment between outcomes, tasks and criteria
- Alignment between what students should learn, what they must do and how their work will be assessed.
- A preview of the completed brief
- PDF export

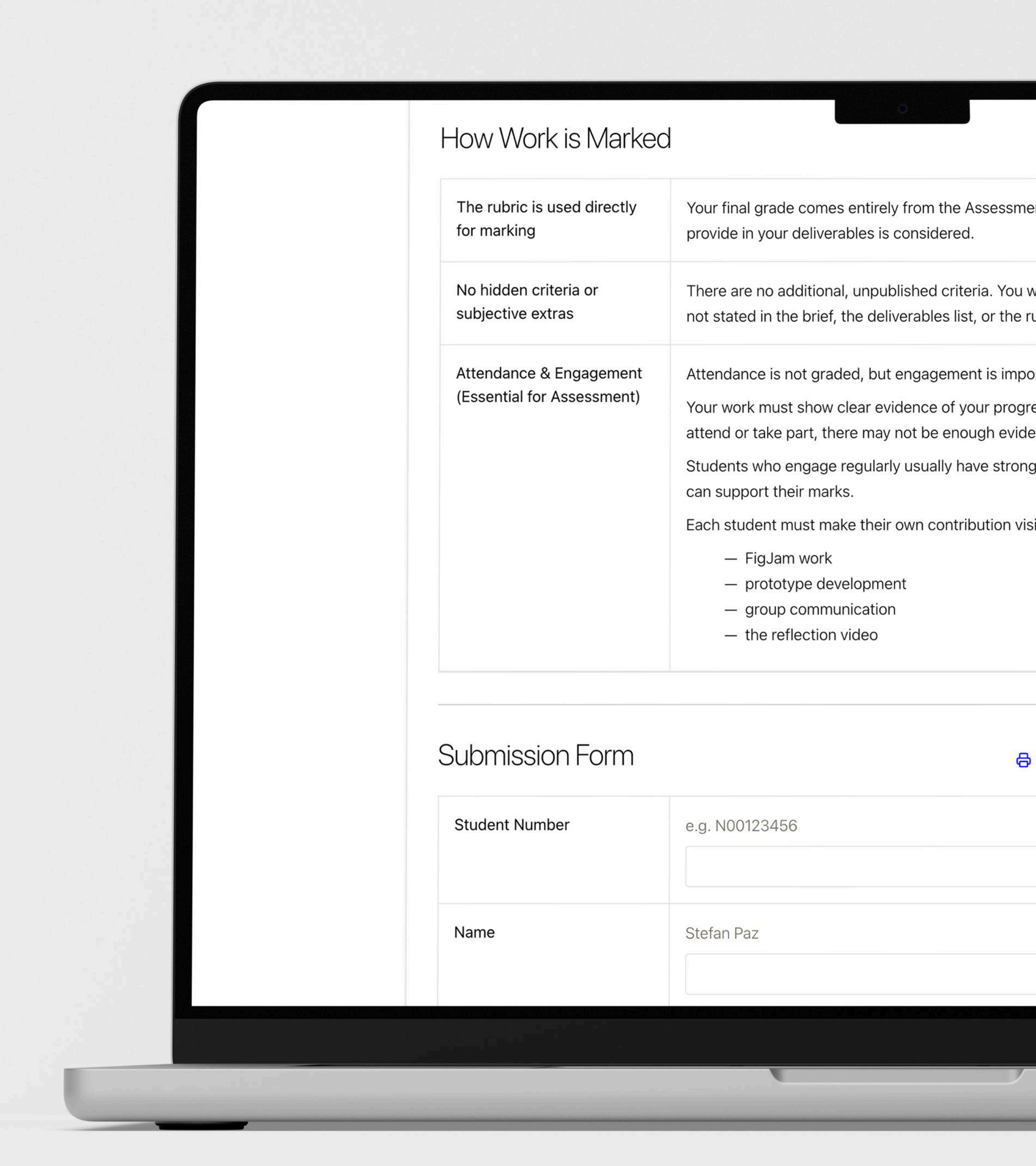


Building a brief

Research findings + implementation

The builder guides the lecturer through the main sections:

- Module and assessment details
- Assessment task
- Learning outcomes
- Submission requirements
- Assessment criteria and Rubrics
- Preview and export



Consistent structure

A repeated structure helps students find important information across different assessment briefs.

The structure remains consistent while the content can be adapted for different disciplines.



Reduced cognitive load

Information is divided into clear sections so that students can focus on one part of the brief at a time.

Reduce cognitive load

UDL: Chunk information into smaller elements

Deliverables	Listen to this section 🔊
Requirements	Your task is to design a prototype for a website catering to third-level students in their final year who are seeking information on opportunities for progression into employment or further study.

Collapsed

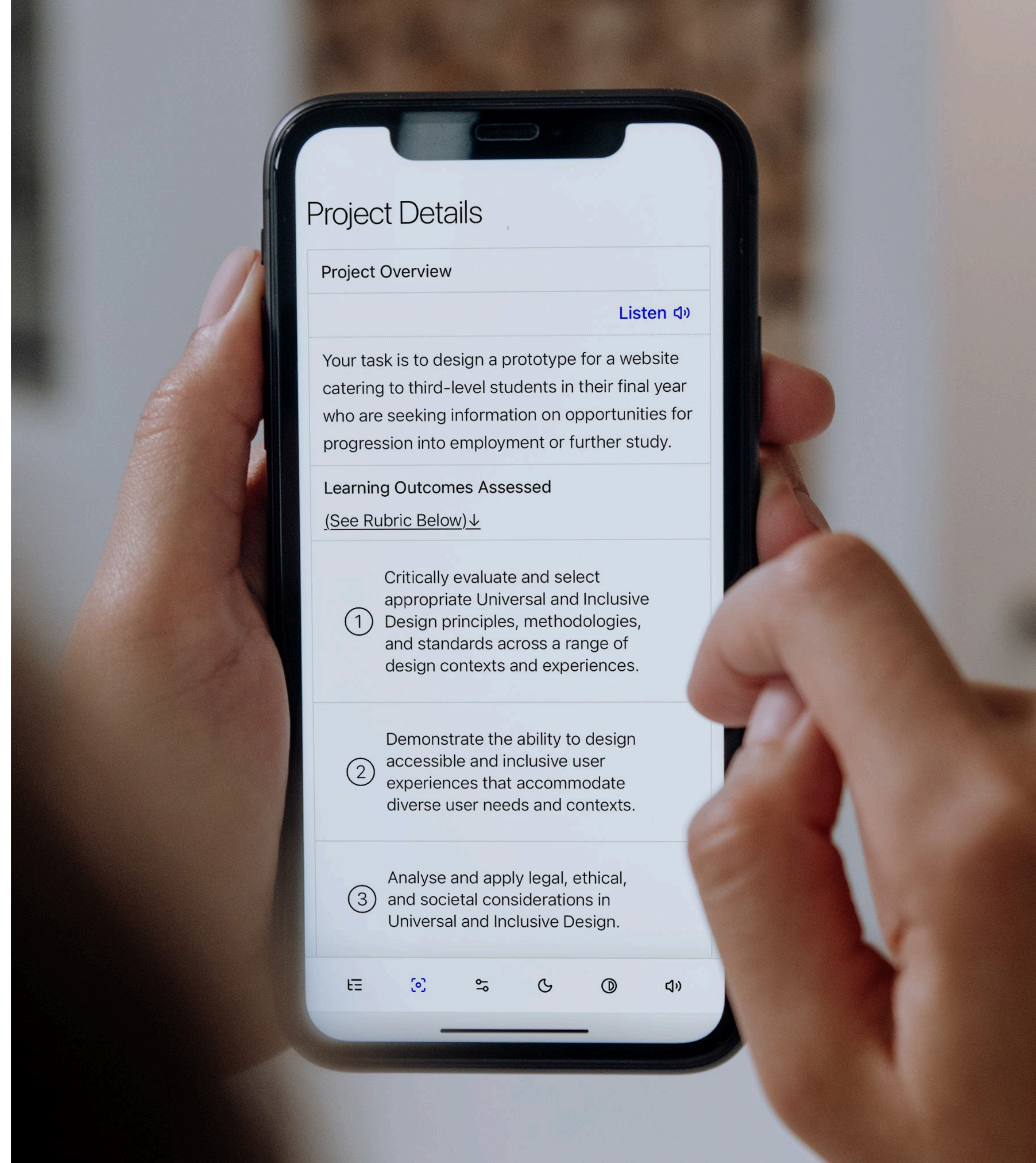
Deliverables	Listen to this section 🔊
Requirements	Your task is to design a prototype for a website catering to third-level students in their final year who are seeking information on opportunities for progression into employment or further study. Based on initial research, the primary goals of the users are as follows: — Be aware of all relevant opportunities as they arise. — Have sufficient information to make informed choices. — Reduce the time spent filtering non-relevant opportunities. — Save and recall specific information for later review. — Share chosen information with others. The primary focus of this assignment is to create an inclusive design that addresses the needs of users with disabilities. Additionally, you will need to consider the information architecture, content design, and visual design of the website.

Expanded

Responsive presentation

The completed brief adapts to different screen sizes.

Students can read the brief on a computer, tablet or phone.



Assessment alignment

The builder prompts lecturers to connect:

- The assessment task
- The learning outcomes
- The assessment criteria

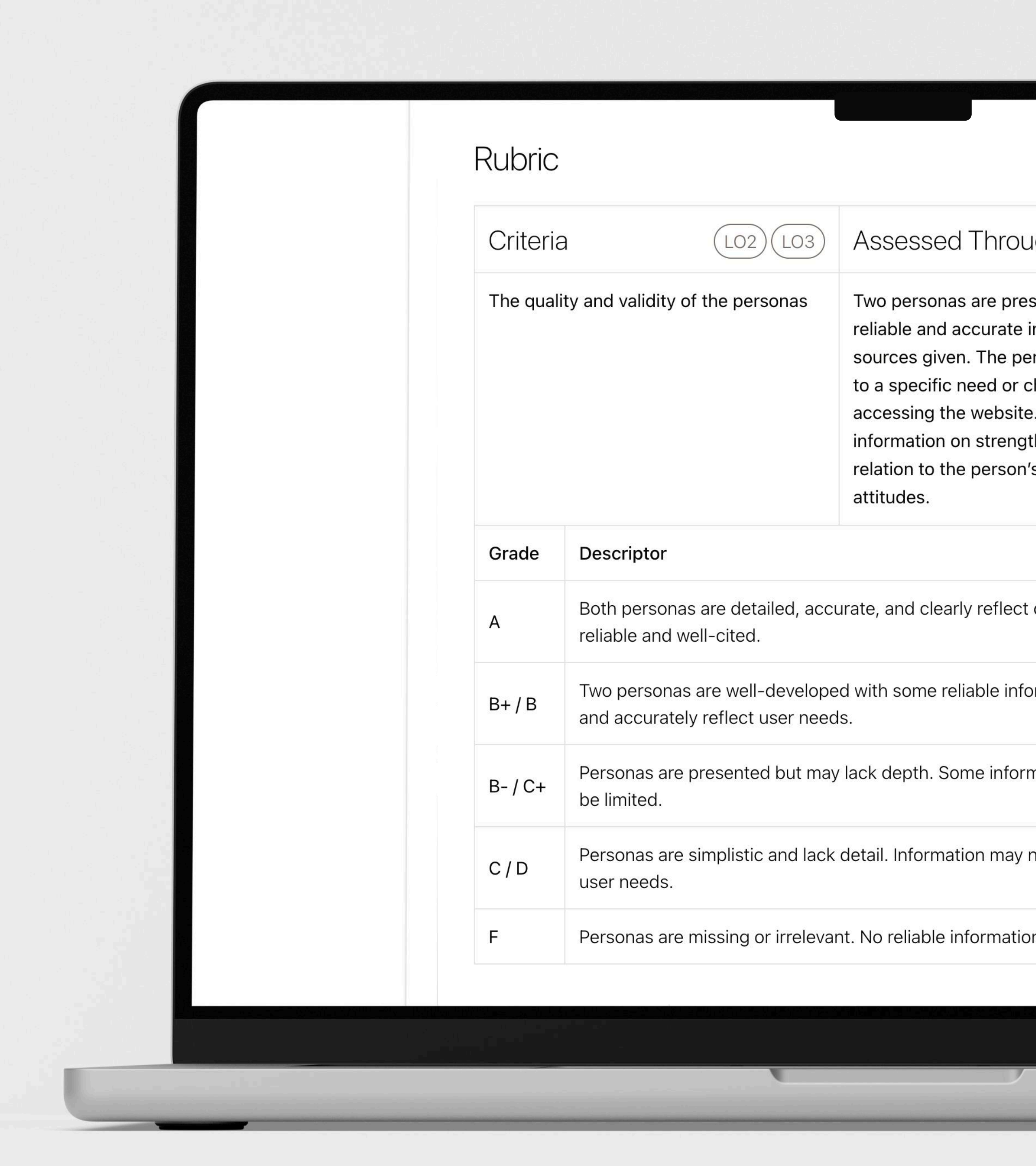
This helps students understand how the different parts of the assessment relate to each other.



Local by design

The OER runs locally in a web browser.

- No account required
- No backend required
- No student information collected
- No information sent to an external server



PDF Export

Once the brief is complete, the lecturer can preview and export it as a PDF.



– The PDF can then be shared through all institutional platforms.



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